

The Noble Dhāraṇī Called "Not Overcome by Epidemics and Living Creatures"

Toh 803 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་རྣམས་དང་སྒོ་ཆགས་ཀྱི་མ་ཚུགས་བ་ཞེས་བ་བྱའུ་གྲུ་སྤྱུ་

The Noble Dhāraṇī "Not Overcome by Epidemics and Living Creatures" (Tibetan: 'phags pa rims dang srog chags kyis mi tshugs pa zhes bya ba'i gzungs) is a very short protective dhāraṇī, or mantra-text, whose Sanskrit title is not given in the source lines and so cannot be confidently supplied. It opens with homage to the Three Jewels, presents a brief mantra, and instructs the practitioner to recite it seven times over a bell, so that wherever the bell's sound carries, birds, wild beasts, worms, rats, and epidemic diseases are warded off. The text is thus concerned with practical protection against disease and harmful creatures through ritual sound. It is Toh 803 in the Kangyur, where it belongs to the Tantra section and, more specifically, to the class of dhāraṇī texts.

The noble dhāraṇī called "Not Overcome by Epidemics and Living Creatures."

Homage to the Three Jewels.

Oṃ vajra vajre. Varṇa śapari svāhā. Namaḥ siṃha vyāghra. Rukṣa tara kṣu. Khathina drāme kha me kha. Caṭṭi ti va ta ye. Roga nī dīpa sa ta ye svāhā.

Recite this mantra seven times over a bell. Wherever its sound is rung out in the surrounding regions, all birds, wild beasts, worms, rats, and epidemic diseases will be warded off. Epidemic

Translator's Notes

- The passage breaks off mid-sentence at "Epidemic," and I have rendered it as it stands. The mantra is transliterated Sanskrit with several corrupt or irregular syllables, such as "varṇa śapari," "caṭṭi ti va ta ye," and "dīpa sa ta ye." These are given as best reconstructed and are not translated, as mantras are conventionally left untranslated. The opening Tibetan title uses "mi tshugs ba" (not overcome, not able to settle or take hold), and the form given in the text reads "mi tshugs bā," which I take as a variant spelling. In the instruction, "dkrol ba" literally means to be sounded or rung, and I took the sentence to describe the bell's sound spreading across the land. "Srin bu" is rendered "worms," though it can also mean insects or vermin generally.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.